DBQ Sourcing 5B: Intended Audience

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What intended audience means

Intended audience is the specific group a document was made to reach, and explaining it earns credit when the student shows how writing *for that group* shaped the message and what that reveals about the prompt.

How it feeds Purpose: the audience is who the author needs to move, so it tells you what the author wants. A speech to Congress asks for laws or money; a magazine article for consumers asks them to buy or think differently; a sermon to a congregation asks for belief or action. Once students name the audience, the purpose sentence nearly writes itself (see 5D).

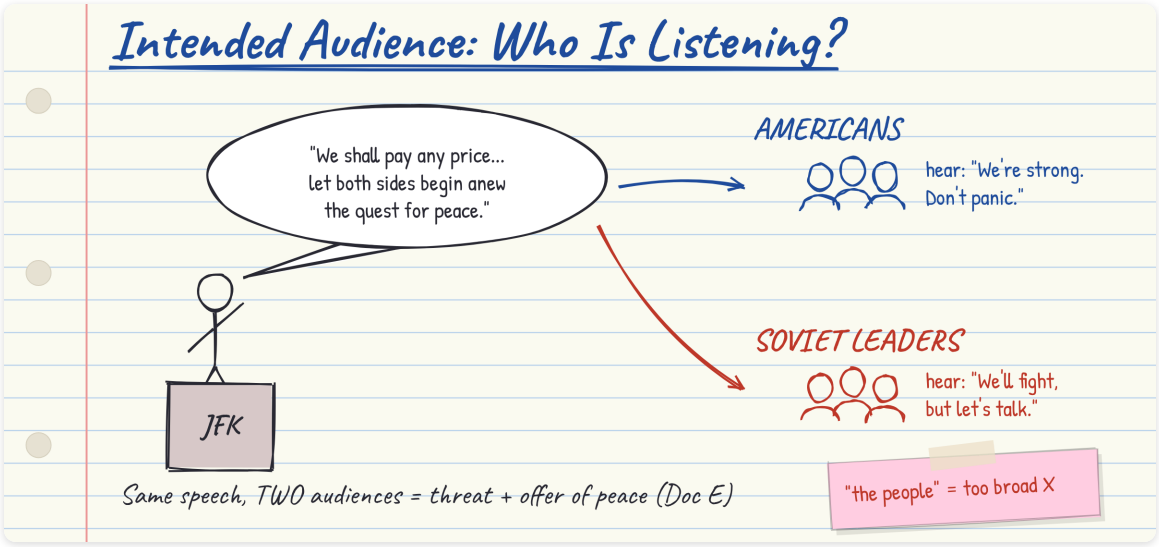
To earn credit, an audience explanation must:

1. **Name a specific group**: "southern Baptist church members," not "the people" or "the government."
2. **Explain the effect**: why the author chose these words, examples, or arguments for that group.
3. **Connect it to the argument**: what reaching that audience shows about the prompt.

Audience is the element most often rejected for being **too broad** in the samples. Precision matters more here than for any other element.

The formula

> "[Author] [wrote / spoke] Document [X] to [specific audience], who [what they believed, wanted, or controlled]. Because of this audience, [author] [emphasizes / frames] [content] in order to [goal], which shows [argument]."



1. **Find the clue in the source line.** Format tells you the audience: speech to Congress, State of the Union, newspaper, magazine, sermon, letter to a named person, press conference.

2. **Narrow it.** Ask "which readers of that outlet?" A Saturday Evening Post article reaches middle-class families, not "Americans."
3. **Say what that audience could do or believed.** Congress funds programs; voters elect; consumers buy; foreign leaders react.
4. **Explain the fit.** Why this message for this group?
5. **Tie to the thesis.** "This shows…"

Cold War DBQ audiences (written for this guide):

Doc	Audience	Why it matters
A, Eisenhower press conference	Reporters and, through them, a frightened public	He is trying to calm "hysteria," so he names the fears out loud.
B, Dulles	Americans and Latin American governments	Justifying intervention in Guatemala as hemispheric defense.
D, Saturday Evening Post	Middle-class families who drive	Sells a defense project as an end to the "traffic jam."
E, Kennedy inaugural	Americans *and* the Soviet Union ("Let every nation know")	Two audiences explain the mix of threat and offer of peace.
G, Eisenhower to Congress	Members of Congress who control spending	Framing education as national security wins votes for funding.

Examples that earned credit

Source	Document	What was credited
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 4 (Furman)	Audience “accurately” explained as southerners sympathetic to slavery who wanted a biblical justification for it.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 2	Audience: U.S. government officials implementing policies for Native American assimilation.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A	Doc 7	Audience: immigrants, “to show that they are not currently regarded as true Americans.”
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 3	Showed how the federal government built public support for intervention by promoting the benefits of highway spending.

College Board model sentences:

> "Harrison's audience was voters in the upcoming election, and the importance of the economy to United States society is demonstrated by the fact that he believed that he could gain a political advantage with these voters by accusing Democrats of harming the economy through their treatment of businesses." (2025 Set 2, Doc 4)
> "The members of the Baptist Church in the South who were Furman's audience showed that there was widespread disagreement in United States society over the meaning of basic ideas about liberty and religious principles…" (2024 Set 1, Doc 4)

Cold War model (written for this guide):

> "Kennedy's inaugural address in Document E speaks to two audiences at once: Americans who feared nuclear war and Soviet leaders who were listening. That is why he pairs 'pay any price' with a request that 'both sides begin anew the quest for peace.' This shows the government tried to ease fear at home by projecting strength while signaling restraint abroad."

Examples that did not earn credit

Source	Attempt	Why it fails
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	Doc 6 (Chávez to the Senate): audience is "the entire government"	"Too broad," and it doesn't explain relevance to the argument.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 6: audience is "the people of America"	Incorrect; the audience was the inhabitants of Puerto Rico. The essay earned the point anyway on five other documents, which is why sourcing extra documents is insurance.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- "The audience of Document A is the American people." Too broad, and no effect explained.
- "Document G was written to Congress." Correct identification, but it stops there. Add what Congress could do and why Eisenhower's framing fit them.
- "The audience of Document D is people who like to drive." Specific, but ignores the defense side of the law and isn't tied to Cold War fears.

Expert tips

- **Why audience matters:** a personal letter might say something very different about a person than a political stump speech, and the difference comes down to audience.
- **A good lead-in:** "The audience of this document was X, and that suggests…" The "suggests…" clause is where the argument connection goes.
- **A caution from the AP Reading:** readers say audience, POV, and purpose attempts often "fall flat" compared with historical situation. That fits the samples here, where vague audiences ("the entire government") were rejected. Use audience when the source line makes the audience obvious and specific.

Grader checklist

1. Is the audience a specific group, not "the people," "America," or "the government"?
2. Is it accurate for this document?
3. Does the essay explain how that audience shaped what the author said?
4. Is it tied to an argument about the prompt?

Four yeses = this document counts toward the two needed.

Feedback stem: "You said the audience of Document [X] is [broad group]. Narrow it (who exactly read or heard this?), then explain why the author's message was aimed at them."